

Essay Writing Competition 2024

Girls' Vision for the Future — Empowering Girls Through Education, Voice, and Recognition

In commemoration of the 2024 International Day of the Girl Child, Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF) organised a national essay writing competition themed 'Girls' Vision for the Future'. Open to secondary school girls across Nigeria, the competition awarded cash prizes of ₦80,000, ₦60,000, and ₦40,000 to the top three positions, with consolation prizes for 4th place. Four finalists were selected, all scoring 90% or above — with the winning essay submitted from a remote village in Ogun State.

Organisation	Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF)
Programme Focus	Education (SDG 4)
Date	October 2024 — International Day of the Girl Child
Theme	'Girls' Vision for the Future'
Eligibility	Secondary school girls across Nigeria
1st Prize	₦80,000 — Ogungbe Favour (91.5%), Ogun State
2nd Prize	₦60,000 — Heritage Ayanwole (91%), Osun State
3rd Prize	₦40,000 — Odukoya Adunola (90.5%), Ogun State
4th Place	Consolation Prize — Okugbesan Oreoluwa (90%), Ogun State
Age Profile	14–15 year olds formed the majority of applicants
Geographic Spread	50% of applicants from Ogun State; entries from multiple states

4	3	91.5%	50%
Prize Winners	States Represented	Top Score	From Ogun State

Overview

In October 2024, Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF) organised an essay writing competition to mark the International Day of the Girl Child. Themed 'Girls' Vision for the Future', the competition invited secondary school girls across Nigeria to articulate in their own words a vision of a world where girls are empowered, educated, and equal — and to put their name forward for recognition.

The competition was designed around GDGF's core SDG 4 (Education) mandate: giving girls not just access to learning, but a platform to demonstrate what that learning produces. Cash prizes and public

recognition were tools of motivation and affirmation. The grading framework — weighting originality at 75% — was designed to reward genuine voice over surface-level compliance.

GDGF's approach to education: The competition is not just about identifying strong writers — it is about creating a moment where a girl from a remote village knows that her vision matters, her words carry weight, and her future is worth articulating out loud.

About the Competition

The competition was open to secondary school girls across Nigeria, with no geographic restriction. Entries were submitted in response to the prompt aligned with the 2024 International Day of the Girl Child theme: 'Girls' Vision for the Future'. Each essay was required to be approximately 400 words.

GDGF received entries from multiple states. The age range of applicants spanned 10 to 18 years, with 14 and 15 year olds making up the majority. Ogun State produced 50% of all applicants and three of the four finalists, with the remaining finalist from Osun State.

A continuing model: Essay writing competitions give girls practice in articulating ambition and claiming space in public discourse — skills as essential as any academic subject. GDGF's role is to create the platform and make the recognition real through prizes and publication.

Grading Framework

Essays were assessed across three criteria to ensure rigorous, transparent, and replicable evaluation:

Criteria	Weight	Detail
Word Count Adherence	10%	400-word target; marks deducted for deviation
Plagiarism / Originality Score	75%	≥90% = 67.5 pts · 70–89% = 52.5 pts · 50–69% = 37.5 pts · ≤49% = 0
Theme Alignment	15%	Connection to IDG 2024 theme: 'Girls' Vision for the Future'

The decision to weight originality (plagiarism score) at 75% reflects GDGF's commitment to authentic voice. The framework rewards girls who write from genuine experience and vision — not from templates or copied material. All four top finalists scored 90% or above, demonstrating a genuinely high standard of original submission.

Results — Top 4 Finalists

Four finalists were selected and publicly announced in commemoration of the 2024 International Day of the Girl Child. Each finalist was notified by email and recognised publicly by GDGF. The top four scores spanned from 91.5% to 90% — a narrow band reflecting both the quality and the rigour of the evaluation.



Girls for Development
Goals Foundation

In commemoration of the
2024 Day of the Girl Child

Essay writing Competition 2024

TOP 4 WINNERS



FAVOUR
91.5%



HERITAGE
91%



ADUNOLA
90.5%



OREOLUWA
90%

Congratulations to all the winners.

Girls for Development Goals Foundation @girls4developmentgoals @GHeFoundationNG

Top 4 Winners — GDGF Essay Writing Competition 2024 · Day of the Girl Child

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Goals FoundationIn com
2024 Day of

ESSAY WRITING COMPETITION

3rd Position

**ODUKOYA ADUNOLA**

(90.5%) OGUN STATE

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1st Place — Ogungbe Favour · 91.5% · Ogun State

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2024 Day of

ESSAY WRITING COMPETITION

4th Position

**OKUGBESAN OREOLUWA**

(90%) OGUN STATE

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2nd Place — Heritage Ayanwale · 91% · Osun State

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2024 Day of

ESSAY WRITING COMPETITION

2nd Position

**HERITAGE AYANWOLE**

(91%) OSUN STATE

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3rd Place — Odukoya Adunola · 90.5% · Ogun State

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2024 Day of

ESSAY WRITING COMPETITION

1st Position

**OGUNGBE FAVOUR**

(91.5%) OGUN STATE

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4th Place — Okugbesan Oreoluwa · 90% · Ogun State



In commemoration of the
2024 Day of the Girl Child

ESSAY WRITING COMPETITION UPDATES

CHECK YOUR EMAILS

TOP 4 FINALISTS ANNOUNCED



1st prize: 80,000NGN

2nd prize: 60,000NGN

3rd prize: 40,000NGN

Consolation prices will be given



Finalist announcement and prize structure — Essay Writing Competition 2024

Position	Winner	Score	State	Prize
1st	Ogungbe Favour	91.5%	Ogun	₦80,000
2nd	Heritage Ayanwole	91%	Osun	₦60,000
3rd	Odukoya Adunola	90.5%	Ogun	₦40,000
4th	Okugbesan Oreoluwa	90%	Ogun	Consolation Prize

Numbers and Statistics

The competition drew applications from secondary school girls across multiple Nigerian states. The demographic profile of applicants and the statistical breakdown of the grading process are documented below.

GIRLS4DEVELOPMENTGOALS

PAGE 06

*Girls Vision for the Future
Essay Competition*

NUMBERS & STATISTICS

As part of our focus on education (SDG 4), we organized an essay competition for the 2024 International Day of the Girl, themed "Girls' Vision for the Future," to remind girls of the value of education. The competition offered cash prizes of 80,000 NGN, 60,000 NGN, and 40,000 NGN for the top three winners, with attractive consolation prizes for the 4th place.

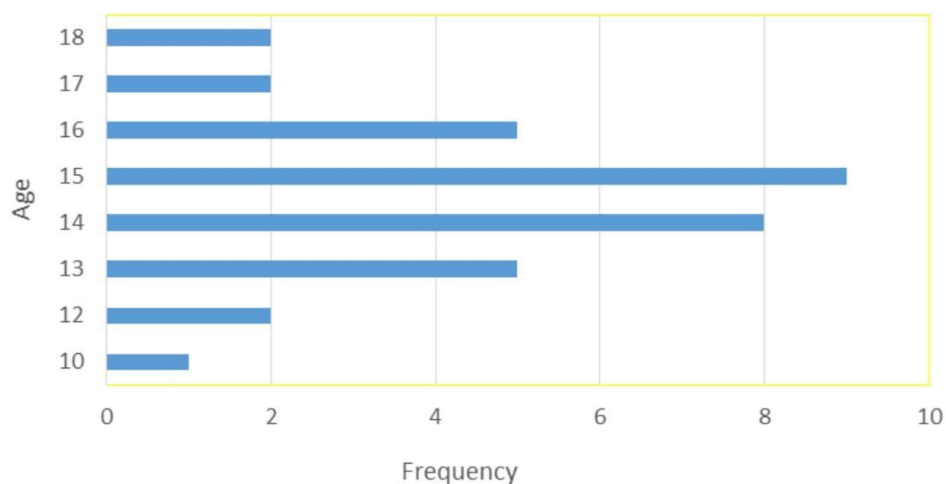
50%

Applicants from Ogun State

14 & 15

Year Olds made up a larger portion of the group

Age of Applicants



How we graded:

- 10% - Adherence to the word count (400 words). The further you deviate from 400 words, the more marks you lose, and the less you write, the lower your score.
- 75% - Plagiarism Score
Plagiarism Score Breakdown:
≥90% = 67.5
70-89% = 52.5
50-69% = 37.5
≤49% = 0
- 15% - Connection of essay to the International Day of the Girls 2024 theme "Girls' Vision for the Future".

Competition Numbers & Statistics — applicant age distribution and grading breakdown

Key Statistical Highlights

- 50% of all applicants were from Ogun State
- 14 and 15 year olds made up the largest share of the applicant pool
- The age range of all applicants spanned 10 to 18 years
- All four top finalists scored 90% or above on the grading framework
- Three of the four top finalists are from Ogun State; one from Osun State
- The top score of 91.5% was achieved by Ogungbe Favour from a remote village, Ogun State

Featured: Winning Essay

The winning essay — 'Story of Change' by Ogungbe Favour, 1st position, 91.5% — is published here as GDGF's practice of amplifying the voices of the girls it serves. Favour writes from a remote village in Ogun State with clarity, ambition, and a direct understanding of the structural barriers facing girls in her community.

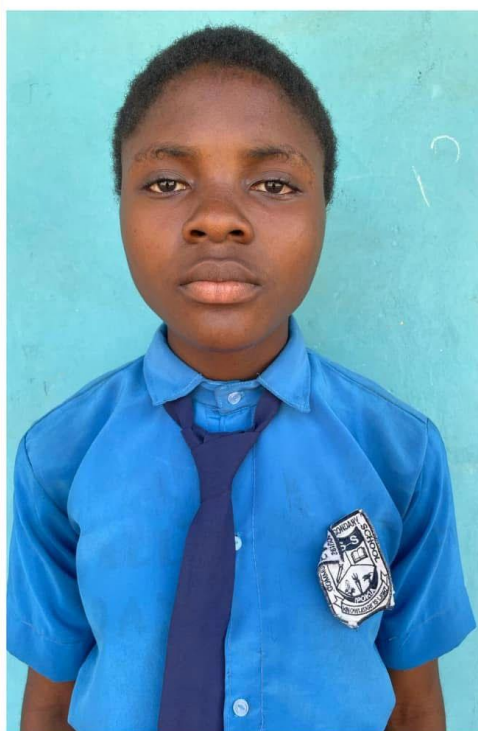
'Story of Change' — Ogungbe Favour (91.5%, Ogun State, 1st Position): It is my vision to touch as many lives as possible. To be able to do that, I aspire to become a registered nurse in the future — not the kind that would bite off your head at the hospital or ignore a child in pain in favour of hot gossip. But with empathy, professionalism, and dedication to healthcare; like we've never had in my village, Ipokia.

I envision a world where I have equal opportunity to attain an excellent education in a good school, same as the city kids or the politician's child. In my vision, I see a girl that has grown into a fearless, bold, confident and empowered nurse. I am not alone in imagining this brave and new world where the future of girls and our ability to be more is not just some future agenda but a reality.

This vision is not a story, it's a call to action. It's a reminder that every girl deserves to dream and to shape her own future. Together, we can create a world where girls are empowered, inspired and unstoppable. — Ogungbe Favour

Favour Ogungbe's Winning Essay

STORY OF CHANGE



It is my vision to touch as many lives as possible. To be able to do that, I aspire to become a registered nurse in the future. Not the kind that would bite off your head at the hospital or ignore a child in pain in favour of hot gossip. But with empathy, professionalism, and dedication to healthcare; like we've never had in my village, Ipokia.

As I look at the future, I can see a world where not just I, but my friends, sisters and girls all over the world can create their own destiny.

I envision a world where I have equal opportunity to attain an excellent education in a good school, same as the city kids or the politician's child. In my vision, I see a girl that has grown into a fearless, bold, confident and empowered nurse.

I am not alone in imagining this brave and new world where the future of girls and our ability to be more is not just some future agenda but a reality. My friends at school, the girls at church, and even the ones who hawk native palm oil soap in the market are equally inspired to dream of a world where their ambitions can become reality. But that is all that we have: a lot of inspiration and a burning desire in our throat to be more than our mothers, to go to places our elder sisters never could. This is not enough! Do we not all deserve access to quality education? Do I not deserve encouragement to explore a diverse range of talents? Education does not only need to be a right but a reality that can fill the gap between privilege and equality.

In my little corner of a remote village in Ogun state, I pursue my ambitions with unwavering determination. But in my vision, I am not alone. I am supported by my family and a large crowd of others who recognize the need for equality, lend their voices and collaborate to challenge my problems.

However, not all girls are as lucky as I am. There are the ones who are rudely confronted with only examples of unwanted pregnancy and early marriage. How should they dream of the future when society's expectations seek to drown their imaginations in the muddy waters of a reality in which the girl-child is a second-class citizen even in their own homes?

Yet, as I look into the future, I see a world where I own my voice, unafraid to speak; I am able to build up others rather than tear down; I welcome confidence, self-love and inner strength. This vision is not a story, it's a call to action. It's a reminder that every girl deserves to dream and to shape her own future. Together, we can create a world where girls are empowered, inspired and unstoppable.

Winning essay page — 'Story of Change' · Ogungbe Favour · 1st Position, 91.5%

Outcomes and Impact

Girls given a national platform for their vision

Every girl who submitted an essay had her voice formally received, read, and evaluated by an organisation that took it seriously. The top four were publicly celebrated. This is a form of recognition that matters — particularly for girls from rural and underserved communities who rarely experience institutional affirmation.

Originality and authentic voice rewarded

By weighting originality at 75% of the total score, GDGF ensured that the competition rewarded genuine expression rather than polished surface performance. The winning essay — submitted from a remote village — demonstrates that authentic voice from marginalised contexts can and does score at the highest level.

High standard of entries confirmed

All four finalists scoring 90% or above, with a top score of 91.5%, demonstrates that secondary school girls in Nigeria are capable of producing strong, original written work when given the right prompt, incentive, and recognition framework. The competition raised the bar — and the finalists cleared it.

Geographic reach across Nigerian states

With applicants from multiple states and finalists from Ogun and Osun, the competition demonstrated GDGF's ability to run a nationally open programme. The concentration of strong entries from Ogun State suggests either targeted outreach success or a particularly engaged school community — worth investigating for future editions.

Cash prizes delivering direct economic benefit

The prize structure — ₦80,000, ₦60,000, ₦40,000, and consolation prizes — delivered direct financial benefit to the finalists and their families. For girls from lower-income communities, prize money also carries a practical signal: talent is valued and rewarded.

Initiative Summary

Initiative name	Girls' Vision for the Future — Essay Writing Competition 2024
Date	October 2024 — International Day of the Girl Child
Organiser	Girls for Development Goals Foundation (GDGF)
Programme	Education (SDG 4)
Theme	'Girls' Vision for the Future'
Eligibility	Secondary school girls across Nigeria
Total prizes	₦180,000 cash prizes + consolation prizes
1st place	Ogungbe Favour · 91.5% · Ogun State
2nd place	Heritage Ayanwole · 91% · Osun State
3rd place	Odukoya Adunola · 90.5% · Ogun State
4th place	Okugbesan Oreoluwa · 90% · Ogun State
Key distinction	Originality weighted at 75% — rewards authentic voice, not polished templates
Documentation	Winner announcement graphics, statistics report, and winning essay published

Learning and Recommendations

The grading framework — particularly the 75% weight on originality — should be formalised as GDGF's standard for all future essay competitions. It produced a credible, rigorous outcome and is straightforwardly defensible to participants and partners.

The winning and runner-up essays should be published in a GDGF annual report or standalone publication. Amplifying the girls' words beyond the competition itself extends the impact at near-zero cost and creates a lasting record.

Future editions should actively target states with lower current representation. The concentration of strong entries from Ogun State suggests that targeted school-level outreach in underrepresented states could significantly broaden the geographic spread.

A junior category (ages 10–13) should be considered for future editions, given the participation of younger applicants. Age-appropriate prompts would make the competition more accessible and relevant to that cohort.

A mentorship or follow-up component — connecting finalists with GDGF's professional network — would deepen the impact beyond recognition and prize-giving. Even a single structured follow-up session would differentiate the competition from others.

Partners and Acknowledgements

- All girls who entered the 2024 Essay Writing Competition — for their courage, vision, and willingness to put their words forward
- Ogungbe Favour, Heritage Ayanwale, Odukoya Adunola, and Okugbesan Oreoluwa — for their exceptional essays and for representing secondary school girls across Nigeria
- GDGF's evaluation team — for rigorous, transparent, and consistent assessment
- Dinners Club Innsbruck and all supporters whose fundraising contributions make programmes like this possible